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Hiring Committee
Fullerton Public Library
City of Fullerton
303 W. Commonwealth Avenue, Fullerton, CA 92832

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Library Technology Assistant position with the Fullerton Public Library. Your posting asks for somebody organized and detail-oriented who can troubleshoot the library's technology, keep it working, write documentation, and talk to staff, vendors and the public without jargon. That describes the part of my current job I was never hired to do and ended up doing anyway.

My title is Direct Mail Production Manager at Young Americans for Liberty, and I look after the organization's archive of everything it has printed and mailed to donors. When I inherited it, finding anything in it meant already knowing where it was. I designed a SQL database for the collection and defined a consistent record for every piece, so that a mail code or a campaign name would be enough to locate something, then worked back through several campaign years and cataloged the existing material against that standard. On top of the database I built a searchable reading room that returns the piece and tells you where the physical original sits on the shelf.

Building it was the easy half. I maintain both systems, I train new staff on them, I wrote the documentation that lets somebody use the catalog without being walked through it, and I am the person colleagues come to when something will not cooperate. That last part is most of what technology support in a library actually is, and I would rather be doing it for patrons and staff in a technical services division than for a fundraising department.

I have built two public websites outside work as well. The Free Knowledge Library is a digital library of political literature drawn from across the ideological spectrum, where I designed the site, the database behind it and the classification scheme, and built the catalog that readers search. I also developed statetrack.net, a service that publishes state campaign finance records for state house and state senate candidates in all fifty states, where the work was data ingestion, normalizing inconsistent records from fifty different reporting regimes, and a search interface an ordinary visitor can use.

On the library and public service side, I handled intake and documentation of donated book collections for the campus library at the University of Austin, including a complete *Harvard Classics* set, and I led visitor tours and helped guests locate materials and service areas. Earlier, as a student registrar at Chapman University's Fowler School of Law, I staffed the service window as the first person students talked to, explained procedures that were not obvious, and processed more than five hundred records accurately and in confidence. Students brought me the basic technical problems too, which is very close to what helping somebody with a public computer or a printer involves.

I should be straightforward about the stated experience. I have well over two years of computer-related work but not a full year inside a library, and your posting allows any combination of training and experience that provides the required abilities. I would rather name that than leave you to find it.

I am also studying for this work rather than drifting into it. I have begun the ALA's Library Support Staff Certification and begin a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring, with a master's in library and information science to follow. Working in a library while I study is worth a good deal more to me than fifteen to twenty hours a week suggests, because it is the practical experience the coursework assumes you are getting somewhere.

I can work a flexible schedule including evenings and weekends. I should say plainly that I am able to relocate. I have family in Southern California who can host me during an interim move, which makes getting out there straightforward.

Thank you for your consideration. I would welcome the chance to talk about the role.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie